

MCCLENNAN COMMUNITY COLLEGE

Leveraging AI at MCC

Foundations • Tier 1

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Nobody here is starting from zero.

Some of you have used these tools daily for two years. Some have used them twice. **Both are welcome, and neither is behind.**

WHAT WE'LL COVER

1

How AI actually works

It predicts the next word. That's why it can sound right and still be wrong.

2

How to spot trouble early

Which tasks are risky, and a three-question check before anything leaves your desk.

3

How to ask it well

Four moves that get better answers, and when to stop trying.

4

What never goes into AI

Student records, financial aid data, and the green, yellow, red line.

5

Two habits to keep

Sign in with your MCC account, and no AI notetakers in sensitive meetings.

THE ROOM YOU ARE ACTUALLY IN

Almost everyone here already uses AI for work.

94%

have used it

For work, in the past six months.

38%

use it daily

Of those users — every working day.

56%

on personal accounts

Non-institutional tools, unsanctioned.

46%

do not know the rules

Unaware of their institution's AI policy.

EDUCAUSE, "The Impact of AI on Work in Higher Education," January 2026 • n = 1,960

PART ONE

What this thing actually is

A working mental model — enough to predict when it will fail you.

THE MECHANISM

It predicts the next word.

That is the whole mechanism. Not retrieval from a database. Not reasoning from known facts. Prediction of the most plausible continuation of your text.

A wrong answer and a right answer are produced by exactly the same process — and they arrive looking exactly the same.

Watch it happen, one word at a time

See it in action →

A DEFINITION

Qualia: what it is like to be something.

The subjective, qualitative, phenomenal properties of conscious experience — the individual “**raw feel**” of what it is like to perceive, feel, or sense something.

Philosophy of mind · the phrase is Thomas Nagel's, 1974

YOU HAVE THEM

The specific sting of being corrected in a meeting. Coffee that has gone cold. Nobody can hand you these in a description — you had to have been there.

IT DOES NOT

There is nothing it is like to be the model. It produces the sentence about the coffee without the taste — and the sentence is all we ever see.

**Every word we have for thinking assumes qualia.
That is the loan we keep making.**

We have no vocabulary for it except our own.

Every verb for what it does was built to describe a mind — it understood, it decided, it wants to help. English offers nothing else, and each word quietly lends it a self.

WHAT WE SAY

“It understood my question.”

“It decided to leave that out.”

“It wants to be helpful.”

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING

The prompt changed which words came next. Nothing was understood.

That continuation scored lower than another. No decision was taken.

It was tuned toward answers people rated well. There is no wanting.

The metaphor is unavoidable. The autonomy it implies is not.

THE KEY IDEA

Sounding right and being right are two different things.

Fluency = how it sounds **Accuracy** = whether it's true

The AI always sounds right. Whether it is right, you have to check.

HOW YOU DECIDE TO TRUST A PERSON

Sounds sure of itself. Smooth, complete sentences.
Specific names, dates and numbers. The right work words. Names a source. Answers right away.

WHAT THE AI IS BUILT TO PRODUCE

Sounds sure of itself. Smooth, complete sentences.
Specific names, dates and numbers. The right work words. Names a source. Answers right away.

Four quick steps · about 5 minutes

See it in action →

**Our error detection was
trained on humans.
It does not transfer.**

A fabricated citation looks more like a real citation than most real citations do.

"Please be accurate" does not work.

- ✗ **"Only use real sources."**
Changes the style of the citations, not whether they exist.
- ✗ **"Say I don't know if you don't know."**
Changes how often it hedges. It cannot know what it does not know.
- ✗ **"Be accurate. This is important."**
Changes the tone. There is no accuracy setting behind it.
- ✓ **Give it the document. Then check the output.**
Grounding plus your verification. That is where accuracy comes from.

HOW TO PREDICT TROUBLE

The shape of the task tells you the risk.

LOW RISK

**You have the facts.
AI shapes them.**

Rewrite this email. Turn these notes into an outline.
Verify tone and completeness.

MEDIUM RISK

**You supply the source.
AI processes it.**

Summarize this document. Pull out the deadlines.
Verify against the source, every time.

HIGH RISK

**You are asking AI
to supply the facts.**

What is our policy on X? When is the deadline for Y?
Verify everything — or do not ask.

The question is never "is AI accurate."

It is: am I asking it to shape information I already have, or to invent information I do not?

The three-question check.

01

What would make this wrong?

Name the failure mode before you go looking. Predicting the error is how you find it.

02

Where did this come from?

Every fact, number, name and citation traced to a source you can open. If you cannot open it, it does not exist.

03

Who is accountable when it is wrong?

You are. Your name is on it, your judgment is in it, and the tool is not a co-signer.

What failure actually looks like.

Administrators sent a campus-wide condolence message about the shooting at Michigan State. It had been generated by ChatGPT — and the attribution line was still in the sent email. Two administrators stepped back from their roles.

NOT THIS

No data disclosed

No student record moved anywhere.

CNN, February 22, 2023

NOT THIS

No law broken

No regulation applied. Nothing to report.

THIS

Judgment

The most damaging AI incident that year.

PART TWO

Prompting as a work skill

Four moves, one habit, and knowing when to stop.

Four moves that reliably work.

01

Context it cannot have

It does not know your audience is already annoyed about this policy, or that the deadline moved twice.

02

One example of good

A single sample of your actual voice beats three paragraphs describing it.

03

Audience and role

"Explain this to a first-semester student" and "to the VP of Finance" produce different documents.

04

Constrain the output

Length, format, what to leave out. "Three bullets, no preamble" removes most of what people dislike.

THE SAME REQUEST, TWICE

Forty seconds of context.

WEAK

"Write an email about the new travel reimbursement process."

STRONG

"I am a department coordinator at a Texas community college. I need to email 40 faculty about a change to travel reimbursement — receipts now go through a portal instead of paper forms. This is the third process change this year and people are frustrated. Short, matter-of-fact, no corporate cheerfulness, with the three steps they have to do. Under 150 words."

Do not rewrite the prompt. Talk back to the output.

01 **Ask for what you want. Then read it properly.**

Write down one specific thing that is wrong — not "it is bad."

02 **Respond to the output. Do not re-specify.**

"The second paragraph is too formal. And you invented a deadline — remove it."

03 **Ask it to critique itself, then decide if you agree.**

"What is the weakest part of this for frustrated adjunct faculty?"

KNOWING WHEN TO STOP

When the prompt is not the problem.

STOP

**It needs facts
only MCC has**

No prompt retrieves our catalog language. Give it the document.

STOP

**The judgment
is the job**

A student appeal. A performance conversation. Decide first.

STOP

**Checking costs
more than doing**

If verifying takes longer than writing it, you have lost.

CAREFUL

**You would lose
a skill you need**

If juniors stop building judgment through the work, the pipeline weakens.

De-skilling concern documented in Ithaka S+R, "AI Adoption in Research Administration," 2025

PART THREE

The MCC data line

The session with real consequences — and the one to get right.

Five regimes, in plain language.

- F** **FERPA — student education records**
Grades, rosters, advising notes, conduct records, transcripts.
- G** **GLBA and the FTC Safeguards Rule — financial aid**
FAFSA data, ISIRs, SSNs. Enforceable since 2023. Reaches Title IV.
- H** **Health, counseling and disability documentation**
Make the category itself the stop sign, not the statute.
- T** **Title IX, conduct and HR investigations**
Hard stop. No drafting, no summarizing, no AI notetakers.
- P** **Personnel and HR data**
Not FERPA, still sensitive. Student-employee records ARE education records.

GLBA: the Gramm–Leach–Bliley Act

A federal law from 1999 that protects people's **financial information**. It applies to MCC because we handle **federal student aid**.

WHAT IT COVERS

- FAFSA data and ISIRs
- Tax and income information
- Social Security numbers
- Bank and routing numbers
- Verification documents
- Hardship stories in aid appeals

WHAT IT REQUIRES

A **written security program** for that information, and **oversight of every outside company** that handles it.

FTC Safeguards Rule, 16 CFR Part 314 · updated rule fully enforceable since June 9, 2023

WHERE AI COMES IN

Pasting an ISIR into a free chatbot hands aid data to a company **MCC never vetted**. That skips the oversight the rule requires.

FERPA · STUDENT RECORDS

Worst case: a letter from the Department of Education.

GLBA · FINANCIAL AID DATA

Worst case: our ability to give students financial aid.

THE LINE

Green, yellow, red.

GREEN — ANY TOOL

Already public

Published catalog and marketing text.
Public policy language. Generic drafting
with no institutional data.

YELLOW — LICENSED TOOLS

Internal, not personal

Draft procedures, agendas, internal
communications, planning documents,
aggregate enrolment. Signed in with
your MCC account.

RED — NO AI TOOL

About a person

Student records • financial aid • health
and disability • Title IX, conduct and HR •
personnel files • SSNs • credentials • legal
hold.

When in doubt, it is red.

12 real situations • about 6 minutes

Sort it yourself →

**If you did not sign in
with your MCC account,
treat it as publishing
to the open internet.**

The distinction is never the brand. It is the contract — and protection attaches to the authenticated session, not the logo on the page.

BEHAVIOUR TWO

AI notetakers.

Otter. Teams recap. Zoom AI Companion. Read.ai. Anything that joins a meeting and starts transcribing.

Never in an advising, counseling, Title IX, conduct, HR investigation or grievance meeting.

No exceptions without written authorization from the Title IX Coordinator or General Counsel.

It is the highest-frequency accidental disclosure in higher education right now — because it attaches without anyone deciding to use it.

TEXAS

Your prompts are probably public records.

MCC is a governmental body. Prompts and outputs created in the course of official business are very likely public information under Government Code Chapter 552, and subject to records retention.

Using a personal account does not take the record out of reach. It just makes it harder to produce — and adds a records-management problem on top.

Write every prompt as though it could be printed in the Waco Tribune-Herald.

What you are leaving with.

KNOW

A mental model

It predicts plausible text. Fluency and accuracy are separate dials. The shape of the task tells you the risk.

DO

Three questions

What would make this wrong? Where did it come from? Who is accountable? (You are.)

HOLD

One line

Green, yellow, red. The sign-in check. No notetakers in the hard rooms. When in doubt, it is red.

Your exit artifact: three tasks classified by risk and by data line • your time-audit task, before and after • and one behavior you are changing, in one sentence.